

Medical Emoji — Insights & Post Kit for ACEP

Prepared for the American College of Emergency Physicians communications team to accompany a post about ACEP's June 5, 2026 support letter for the Medical Emoji Project. Everything here is drafted to be lifted directly or adapted to ACEP's voice.

The drive-home point: ACEP is the first national, multi-specialty physician society to endorse the entire Medical Emoji effort at once — its letter names all ten concepts now in development. The emoji aim to give clinicians and patients a familiar, globally available visual layer for organ systems, infection, cardiac monitoring, transfusion, medication use, and weight-based care.

1. Background (2–3 sentences for the post)

The Medical Emoji Project advocates for adding high-utility medical symbols to the Unicode Standard, the global system behind the emoji on every phone. In 2019, emergency physician **Shuhan He, MD** (Massachusetts General Hospital) and collaborators helped win Unicode approval for the **anatomical heart**  **and lungs** , which shipped on billions of devices in 2021 and were documented in *JAMA*. The project is now pursuing ten further concepts — and ACEP has formally endorsed that work.

2. Why ACEP's endorsement matters

- It is a **clinical and professional endorsement from a national society**, the kind of broad-applicability signal Unicode weighs when evaluating proposals.
- It covers **all ten current concepts at once**, rather than a single organ — a first for the project.
- It frames medical emoji where emergency medicine lives: **clear communication under time pressure, across languages, literacy levels, ages, and disabilities** — for patient education, discharge instructions, public health messaging, and medical education.
- ACEP is explicit that these symbols **add to**, and do not replace, clinical language or professional interpretation.

3. The ten concepts ACEP named (with a clinical hook for each)

Use any subset. Each pairs a concept with a fact that lands quickly.

Concept	Why it matters
Liver	Liver disease causes ~2 million deaths a year worldwide; ~25% of Americans have non-alcoholic fatty liver disease.
Kidney	Chronic kidney disease affects ~10% of the global population.
Stomach	GERD carries an estimated \$18B in direct and \$75B in indirect costs annually.
Intestine / Bowel	Colorectal cancer is the 3rd most diagnosed cancer and 2nd leading cause of cancer death.
White Blood Cell	Infection and immunity shaped history from the Black Plague to COVID-19; 15.5M U.S. primary-care visits for infectious disease in 2016.
ECG / EKG	One person dies every 36 seconds from cardiovascular disease in the U.S.
Spine	Low back pain is the #1 cause of years lived with disability worldwide.
Blood Product	Every 2 seconds, someone in the U.S. needs blood.
Pill Pack	~50,000 opioid overdose deaths in the U.S. in 2019.
Weight Scale	Over 2 billion people worldwide live with overweight or obesity.

4. How Unicode emoji approval works (one line of context)

Unicode reviews each proposal against published criteria — distinctiveness, expected usage, image licensing, and broad applicability — through a formal annual process. Society support speaks to clinical relevance and broad applicability.

5. Suggested post copy

X / Twitter (single post)

The American College of Emergency Physicians has endorsed the @medicalemoji project — supporting standardized medical emoji for liver, kidney, stomach, bowel, white blood cell, ECG, spine, blood products, pill packs, and weight scales. Clearer health communication, on every device. 🦋 🦋 🦋

X / Twitter (thread opener, if going longer)

1/ ACEP is backing a push to add medical emoji to the global Unicode Standard — simple visual anchors for common clinical concepts that patients and clinicians can use across languages, literacy levels, and devices. Here's why it matters 🏥

LinkedIn / website post

ACEP supports standardized medical emoji

Emergency physicians communicate in time-sensitive settings where clarity matters across languages, literacy levels, ages, and abilities. The American College of Emergency Physicians has issued a letter of support for the Medical Emoji Project's work to add high-utility medical symbols to the Unicode Standard — the system behind the emoji on every phone.

The endorsement covers ten concepts: anatomical liver, kidney, stomach, intestine/bowel, white blood cell, ECG/EKG, spine, blood product, pill pack, and weight scale. These symbols would add a familiar, globally available communication layer for patient education, discharge instructions, public health messaging, and medical education — complementing, never replacing, clinical language.

The project's earlier work helped bring the anatomical heart 🫀 and lungs 🫁 to Unicode in 2021. Learn more: medicalemoji.org

Suggested hashtags

#MedicalEmoji #EmergencyMedicine #HealthLiteracy #DigitalHealth #HealthEquity
#MedEd

Suggested tags / mentions

- Project: **@medicalemoji** (X), Medical Emoji (medicalemoji.org)
- Project lead: **Shuhan He, MD** (@ShuhanHeMD on X)

6. Assets in this kit

- **medical-emoji-acep-grid.png** — labeled grid of all ten endorsed concepts (ready for a post header / hero image, white background).

- **emoji/** — the ten individual concept images as transparent PNGs ($\approx 900\text{--}1000\text{px}$), clearly named, for flexible layout.
- **ACEP support letter (PDF)** — <https://medicalemoji.org/documents/ACEP-Medical-Emoji-Support-Letter-2026.pdf>
- **Endorsements page** — <https://medicalemoji.org/endorsements>

7. Image rights

The emoji concept images were produced for the Medical Emoji Project and are provided for ACEP's use in communications about this endorsement. For any other reuse, please contact info@medicalemoji.org.